National Security: How India is Taking a Global Lead

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Throughout history, the most successful nations have been marked not by revolution but by ongoing evolution. They evolve to fit changing times — and they evolve to shape the times. India has firmly entered this phase in recent years. The country's internal development is accelerating while its influence on world affairs is growing. Now consider how India is evolving in its approach to a key issue area: national security.

Countries everywhere face a greater, more complex range of security threats than they did in the past. It is no longer enough to focus only on defending against military attacks and insurrections. Current thinking tends to align with the comprehensive view taken by the security scholar Prabhakaran Paleri, a retired officer who once headed the Indian Coast Guard. In his seminal 2008 book, National Security: Imperatives and Challenges, Paleri argued that the true goal of security is to preserve the overall "well-being" of a nation. People should be able to pursue their lives in a society that functions without being constantly or massively disrupted. And major disruptions, Paleri noted, can be caused by many factors other than armed violence. He concludes that a country must pay attention to economic security, environmental security, and numerous more "elements" of national security as well.

For the sake of brevity, I wish to highlight three major security elements that India is working on as we speak. They are cybersecurity, climate change, and international trade and travel. In each of these, the government is mounting efforts that can help to secure India's continued rise, while also positioning India as a global leader.

Cybersecurity is a constant concern for anyone using digital connectivity. A vast international cyber-underworld launches daily waves of attacks aimed at stealing money, spying on confidential data, and freezing the systems of businesses and public agencies with ransomware. As India grows more prosperous, it becomes a more inviting target. Cyber-attacks on organisations in India increased by 15% from 2022 to 2023, according to the multinational security firm Check Point. The situation calls for sustained responses on two fronts: strengthening the security of India's digital systems and chasing down cybercriminals who might be based here. Since no single magic bullet can solve all problems, the government is working on these tasks through a web of interconnected initiatives. For example:

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology plays a lead role in digital policy and houses CERT-In, the central Computer Emergency Response Team for India, while the Home Ministry handles policing of cybercrime and related matters. Last summer, Parliament passed the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, giving India a legal framework and standards for data handling similar to the strong measures found in the EU. India also has a National Cyber Security Coordinator charged with harmonising federal efforts across the board.

And perhaps India's greatest contribution to global cybersecurity over the long term will come in the form of sheer brainpower. Various surveys show that India now has the world's second-largest population of software engineers: about 5.8 million, surpassing the 4.4 million in the US and trailing only China's estimated 7 million. These engineers, along with India's other IT professionals, constitute a digital army for designing secure systems and repelling cyber-attacks in the years ahead. Indeed many are now forming startup companies dedicated to security. One sign of their potential surfaced at last November's Black Hat MEA (Middle East & Africa) conference in Riyadh. This meeting hosted a global pitch competition for newly formed cybersecurity startups. Six of the eight entrants, including the winner, were from India.

Climate change has already begun to take a serious toll. The past several years have seen record-breaking amounts of economic losses worldwide from climate-related natural disasters. Additional dire effects — which could range from loss of agricultural land to mass migrations forced by climate change — are still building up. Here again, India's goals are twofold. The nation must curb emissions of greenhouse gases while protecting its people from the worst impacts, and progress is being made in both areas.

India's plans to reduce carbon emissions were generally praised in a 2023 report from the Center on Global Energy Policy at Columbia University. The report called India a potential role model for developing nations, stating, in part: "India's 2070 net-zero goal is ambitious for an emerging market. Crucially, if successful in meeting its climate commitments over the next seven years, India could offer a developmental model wherein a country continues to grow and prosper without significantly increasing its energy or carbon footprint."

India furthermore seems well equipped for the challenges ahead. TERI, The Energy and Resources Institute in New Delhi, traces its founding to 1974 and is one of the world's original centres devoted to research and outreach in sustainable development. Other climate institutes and centres have been formed throughout the country. With climate change, as with cybersecurity, India's ever-growing pools of scientific expertise promise to be a significant asset.

Security of international trade and travel is essential in today's interconnected world. Ideally, a country's citizens should be free to work, do business, or visit just about anywhere without facing undue obstructions. India of course has been a pioneer in this regard. The Indian diaspora is the world's largest. It typically benefits the countries that admit Indians. And today, India's government is taking steps to open new doors internationally.

One example, conceived through partnership with the US, is the plan for new trade corridors linking India with the Middle East and Europe. Another example, smaller but significant, was this year's opening of the first Hindu temple in Abu Dhabi — a clear welcome sign from a Muslim state. But there is an underlying political strategy that looms most important of all.

India is now being hailed as a champion of a new approach to international relations called "minilateralism." The gist of this strategy is conceptually very simple. It consists of partnering with other nations, case-by-case, on the basis of mutual interests rather than shared ideologies or values. Given India's history as a nonaligned nation, such a strategy fits the country naturally. Certainly, negotiating the details of a particular joint venture may be tricky. But when practised consistently, this selective partnering can build bridges between countries that might otherwise be mired in hostilities and sanctions between competing blocs.

Is minilateralism the path to new, more peaceful and secure world order? Only time will tell. For now, we can definitely say that it stands as yet another realm in which India is leading the way forward.